



the turbulence created by a traditional ship's superstructure. The *Argus* was just entering service as World War I ended.

BETWEEN THE WARS

During the inter-war years there was impressive progress in the development of aircraft carriers in France, Japan, and the US, among others, despite the determination of some naval commanders to concentrate on battleships. The first purpose-built carriers appeared in the 1920s. British naval aviation was held back after the decision to give control of all military aircraft to their Royal Air Force. By 1939, when this unsatisfactory arrangement ended, the British Royal Navy had good-quality carriers, but its aircraft were obsolete. This allowed the US and Japan to take the lead in naval aviation.

“The war would end with the aircraft carriers the fleet's main striking force”

BRITISH FLEET AIR ARM PILOT CHARLES LAMB, WAR IN A STRINGBAG, 1977



The US Navy followed the conversion of its USS *Lexington* and USS *Saratoga* battlecruisers, built 1920–27, with the purpose-built Yorktown class of carriers, introduced from 1937 onwards. Japan was especially successful in developing a carrier fleet, placing great importance on pilot training and the design of naval aircraft. It soon became apparent that dive-bombers and torpedo bombers were the best aircraft types for attacking enemy ships.

WAR IN THE PACIFIC

The early years of World War II repeatedly demonstrated that even the most heavily gunned warships were vulnerable to air attack. This was especially true in the Pacific War. The surprise attack mounted by a Japanese carrier task force on the US naval base at Pearl Harbor, Hawaii, in December 1941, was an unforgettable illustration of the devastating potential of naval air power, and forced American naval commanders to recognize that carriers were their capital ships. As a result, battleships, cruisers, and destroyers were given the role of protecting them.

The vast industrial capacity of the US helped to turn the tide. Carriers and naval aircraft were produced in astonishing quantity, enabling them to overwhelm and even eliminate the Japanese carrier fleet over the course of 1944. By 1945, the Allies had 40 carriers in their fleet off Okinawa, and the Americans had established themselves as undisputed world leaders in naval aviation.

▲ A CROWDED FLIGHT DECK

Taking off and landing aircraft on the deck of a carrier was a complex and accident-prone procedure under combat conditions. Here, Douglas SBD Dauntless dive-bombers form a line on the deck of USS *Yorktown*.

KEY EVENTS

1914–45

- **1914** Britain's Royal Naval Air Service attacks airship sheds at Cuxhaven, Germany, in the first sea-launched attack on a land target.
- **1922** The Japanese navy commissions *Hosho*, the first purpose-built aircraft carrier. Britain's HMS *Hermes*, which was laid down in 1918, is completed shortly after.
- **1941** Japanese carrier-borne aircraft attack the US naval base at Pearl Harbor, Hawaii, sinking or damaging 18 American ships.
- **1942** The Battle of Midway – a long-range duel between American and Japanese aircraft carriers – is fought in the mid-Pacific. The opposing fleets do not engage with their guns.
- **1943** The US Navy establishes a Fast Carrier Task Force to spearhead its Pacific campaign. The Task Force comprises a core of aircraft carriers escorted by big-gun warships.
- **1945** Japan's *Yamato*, the largest and most heavily armed battleship ever built, is sunk by American naval aircraft.